



Cuneiform inscription
c.3200 BCE

The earliest written language was cuneiform—a set of symbols inscribed on wet clay with a stylus.

Early mail
1635

For centuries, messages were sent either through traders or by special courier. In 1635, King Charles I of Great Britain opened up his postal service to the public for the first time.

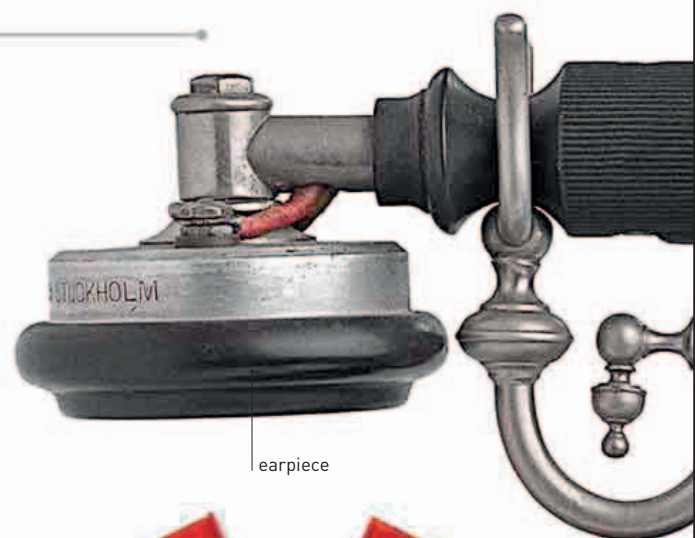


Message carrier
Early 20th century

The idea of using specially trained pigeons to carry mail originated in Persia. Messages would be placed inside metal carriers and attached to pigeons' legs.

Semaphore flags
1792

The first semaphore system (visual signaling using flags) was developed by French engineer Claude Chappe. Signals could be sent across a network of towers but were limited by the weather.



earpiece

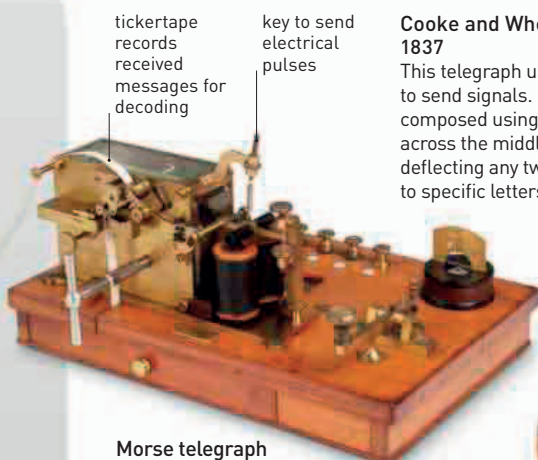


COMMUNICATION

TECHNOLOGY FOR TALKING AND SENDING MESSAGES OVER LONG DISTANCES HAS SHAPED THE MODERN WORLD

The ability to communicate complex ideas through language is a key trait separating humans from animals. In recent years, technological advances have enabled us to send messages faster than a person can travel.

Most prehistoric cultures communicated solely through the spoken word, relying on an oral tradition to pass on or record important information. The appearance of writing in the 4th century BCE transformed human society forever. However, written messages still had to be delivered by hand. It was only in the 19th century that the harnessing of electricity paved the way for modern forms of instantaneous communication.



Morse telegraph
1836

American inventor Samuel Morse designed a telegraph that could send signals over long distances along a single wire. His colleague Alfred Vail devised a code that used short and long pulses ("dots" and "dashes") to represent letters of the alphabet.

key to send electrical pulses

tickertape records received messages for decoding

Cooke and Wheatstone telegraph
1837

This telegraph used electricity to send signals. Messages were composed using the five needles across the middle of the grid; deflecting any two would point to specific letters.



display shows 20 most widely used letters



Early payphone
1905

By the 20th century, "payphones" were installed in public places. Several phones would be connected, with calls being directed by operators at a single exchange.

Bell's electric telephone
1876

Alexander Graham Bell's telephone transmitted sound using electrical signals. As the signal reached the receiver, a metallic disk would vibrate, producing soundwaves.



winding the handle sends a high-voltage signal to the exchange